

customer needs” or “I learned how to resolve conflict between coworkers.”

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Training

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List every non-college course you have ever taken including professional development (leadership training) and technical training (CPR, Photo-shop, Bloodborne Pathogens); these may include one-day seminars, series of courses leading to professional certification, and self-paced computer-based or independent study.

Explain what you learned and, if possible, how you have applied this knowledge to your career and personal life.

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Volunteer activities

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List all extracurricular activities including company task forces and committees (if not mentioned under work experience), trade associations, civic groups, and interest groups.

Describe what you did (planned social events, arranged guest speakers) and what you learned (how to get multiple bids for catering, types of speakers who appeal to certain audiences).

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Travel

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List all travel experiences that are relevant: locally, nationally, and globally.

Describe your travel experiences (e.g., went camping in the mountains, took a mission trip to Guatemala) and what you learned (e.g., how to cook a meal over an open fire, improved your language skills).

If you need to develop a theme to which all of your experience relates, consider the common elements of your experiences (which may be easier upon reflection rather than before you start the process). A theme may be that you’ve enjoyed learning about the historical situation of a problem before proposing a solution, or you’ve used visual tools to communicate with people. This is where counselors or faculty members could be very helpful.

You may need to prove that your learning corresponds directly to a specific course offered by the college or university; or, you demonstrate only that you have learned something of value and/or relevant to your academic goals.

Warnings:

You will most likely need to pay an upfront portfolio assessment fee, which may be nominal or it may equal tuition expenses associated with the credit hours (in which case you will have saved time but not money).

Credit is not guaranteed.

Credits earned through CPL may not be eligible for transfer to other institutions. — **Julie Rains**